



DEMIGOD™

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While some shortcomings overshadow its expansive cross-genre vision, Demigod still deftly combines RTS, Action, RPG and resource management elements into an enticing smorgasbord of war gaming.

You can choose to play one of eight Demigods and upgrade them with new items and abilities as they level up during a match. There are two types of Demigods: Assassins -- standalone creatures that excel in hand-to-hand combat, and Generals -- commanders that possess unique support abilities. Your objective changes depending on the game type: Conquest involves annihilating your enemy's citadel while in Slaughter, you have to defeat all enemy units.

The gameplay and the mood vary admirably from character to character. For example: the Demigod Rook's 'Shadow of the Colossus' inspiration accentuates his role as a walking titan of archery and laser towers while Oak's tactics center on buffing up fellow soldiers to topple the enemy amongst a Helm's Deep-like tension. No, there's no story, no greater purpose for these mystical beings pummeling the tar out of

each other -- only Skirmish and Tournament modes existing in a vacuum. You prepare teams of Demigods, choose a map, and fight. The game's appeal lies in its customizability. Even the most novice player can instantly create a short instant-action match while skilled RTS nuts can tinker to their hearts' content, settling into a marathon of flag captures, portal sieges and beastly duels. Gold can be spent to buff up your Citadel, add new units (such as angels and priests) and improve the stats of existing buildings.

Time spent playing is notched as achievements, where different ranks are obtained depending on deeds accomplished. The list includes "Kill 50 Demigods", "Kill Demigod 10 Levels Higher", and so on. While offering some bragging rights, the achievement system also provides a much needed direction in the absence of a plot.

Demigod's graphical beauty is equal parts scale and artistry. Each unit is meticulously detailed and the Demigods animate smoothly, both in battle and in death. The environments are your rote medieval fantasy settings but they amply show off stunning atmospheric fog, realistic textures, and multiple real-time shadows. The score is cinematic with sweeping orchestras that erupt at eminent moments. The voice-acting and sound direction is also top-notch -- from the

battle cries of Demigods to the toppling of Citadels.

Demigod does a whole lot right but fudges up the basics of RTS design more often than not. The game degenerates into one enormous cluster of chaos, as units disregard orders and generally riot. This isn't a big deal when playing as an Assassin but it quickly kills the uniqueness of a General when your units are bent on playing "Tag, you're it!" with archery trebuchets. While formations would have lessened the pandemonium, they're surprisingly absent. Guiding a Demigod from one distant point to another, especially on the larger maps also gets tedious: dodgy path-finding ensures that a point-click-and-forget mode of travel is also futile -- a unit will invariably find itself trapped in a corner when he's not taking the long way around. Couple both with deaths a-plenty and you get an unappetizing recipe for frustration. Another irritant -- you'll be constantly informed of progress throughout a battle. It's helpful and imperative to know your status, but the game constantly updates you on the availability of upgrades, flag captures -- every minutiae! Being informed about your army attacking enemy HQ or of your crumbling towers to the east, while you're defending the west, quickly becomes repetitive and annoying.

Despite coming from developers with excellent titles under their belt, Demigod doesn't make claims to being revolutionary. Deep down, it's still a game that forsakes tactics for old-fashioned, special attack-filled mobbing. There are few games that cater to such simple pleasures while still offering an immersive Tolkien-esque audio-visual experience, and Demigod easily makes the grade. Though working your way up in difficulty against the computer will suffice, the lack of any tutorials can be extremely off-putting to newbies. Players will doubtless find the game's real appeal to be online play, even with DoTA still reigning in popularity. Despite its flaws, you really won't find what Demigod provides anywhere else, be it a lean season in gaming or not. However those searching for an epic single-player quest may feel short-changed. **d**

Developer: Gas Powered Games, Stardock, Publisher: Take Two, Atari, Number of Players: 1-8, Genre: Real time strategy, Action

SCORE: 8/10

System Requirements:
3 GHz Processor (Multicore supported), 1 GB RAM, 256 MB 3D Video Card (ATI Radeon 2600 / Nvidia GeForce 7600 or better)